

THE WATSON WATCH

Book One

The Case of the Jade Dragon

NCAISM

SpellBee Learning · Sampler: chapters 1–3

The Watson Watch — Book One: The Case of the Jade Dragon

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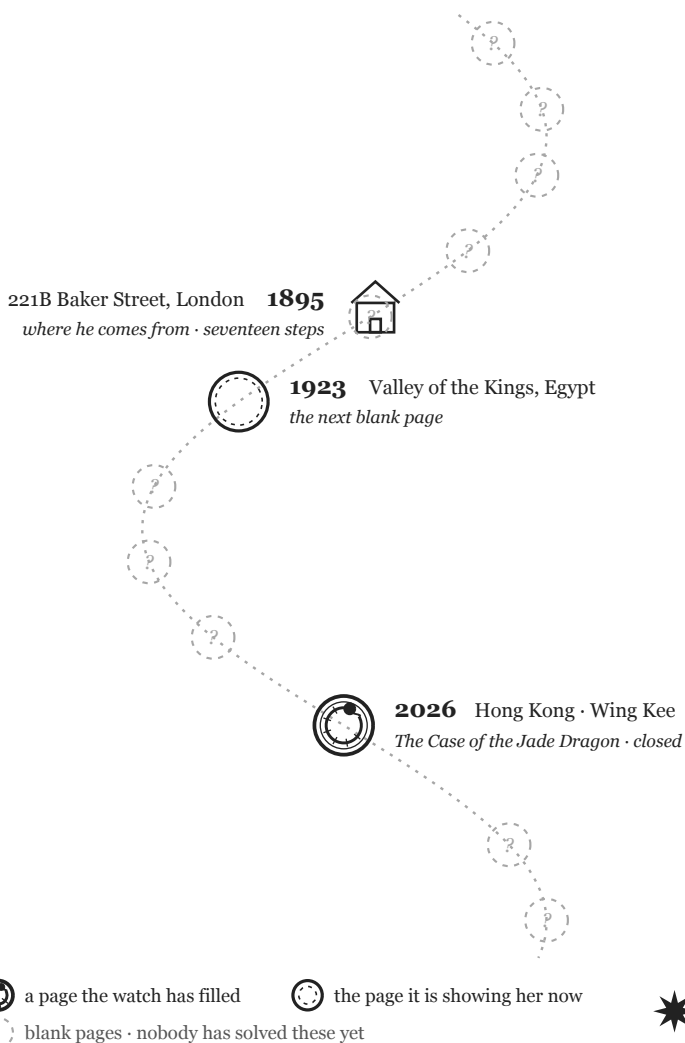
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First edition.

WHERE THE WATCH HAS BEEN

— and where it has not, yet —



Twelve hollows. Only cases nobody ever solved. It never opens the way home until the page is filled.

CHAPTER ONE

The Key



The typhoon was still far out at sea, but Hong Kong already knew it was coming.

It was a Friday. School closed at noon. The sky over the harbour had turned a strange purple-grey, the air smelled of hot metal and rain, and every sparrow in Sai Ying Pun, which was Sam's corner of the city, had vanished.

Sam Wong-Watson stopped on the corner of Queen's Road, took out a battered notebook, and wrote:

#211: Before a typhoon, all the sparrows disappear. Where do they go?

The notebook was called *Things That Don't Add Up*. This one was her fourth; the first three were full. Whenever something didn't add up, it went in the book. A person, a sound, a missing sparrow. She wrote it in English, because English was for school and secrets, and home was Cantonese. On the cover, in smudged ink, she had drawn an eight-pointed star. She had drawn the same star on all four covers. She did not know why. She had simply always drawn it.

"You could just ask a teacher about the sparrows," said her best friend Kit, who was eating curry fishballs off a wooden stick and reading the class group chat at the same time. The chat was forty-seven typhoon emojis and one news link. "Or you could help me carry noodles. I bought nine cups. If the storm knocks the whole city down, I am ready." She said it quite seriously.

"Nine cups and what else?"

"A mango."

That was Kit. Taller than Sam by a head, glasses always slipping, she never worried about anything except running out of food.

"Did you see the dragon thing?" Kit held up her phone. Under the emojis was a photo of an empty shop window and a headline: JADE DRAGON VANISHES FROM LOCKED SHOP. "Sheung Wan. Cameras on all night, nobody went in, nobody came out, and it's gone. The police are saying *impossible*." She said the word as if it were something delicious. "That one should go in your book."

Sam looked at the photo for a long moment. Then she looked at the sky, which was getting darker, and put the notebook away.

"Later," she said. "Sparrows first."

They split up at the market street. Sam ran the last block through the first fat drops of rain, each one landing on the pavement as big as a coin, and arrived home soaked through her PE kit, because Friday was the day for PE.

Her family's food stall stood at the bottom of their building. It was called Wing Kee, and it was a dai pai dong: a kitchen on the pavement, green-painted iron with a canvas roof, eight folding tables, and the best clay-pot rice on that side of the island. Tonight nobody was eating. Sam's father was stacking the tables and roping them down. Her mother hurried past with a chilli jar under each arm. And in the middle of it all stood her grandmother, a tiny woman with an iron-grey bun, holding the big steel ladle she used for soup — and for giving orders.

The whole street called her Yan-je. Sam called her Po-po.

Clang. Po-po struck the ladle once against the rim of the wok.

In the Wong family, two clangs meant *food is ready*. One clang meant *come here, now*. Sam came, dripping, in the rubber slippers she had put on at the door after kicking off her wet trainers.

Po-po looked at her for a long moment. Then she reached behind the stove, took a key off a nail, and pressed it into Sam's hand. It was old brass, on a loop of red string, still warm from hanging near the fire.

"Storeroom," she said. "Rice sacks off the floor. Water is coming up the lane."

Sam stared at the key.

The storeroom was the little room behind the stall, and in eleven whole years she had never once been allowed inside it. She had asked, at six, and been told no. She had asked at nine, with reasons, and been told no with a ladle. At ten she had stopped asking and started watching the door instead, which was how the notebook had begun. Po-po went in. Things came out — bamboo steamers, the good vinegar, once an entire roast goose. But the door always closed behind her, and it always stayed closed.

"Door gets stuck in wet weather," Po-po said, turning back to the wok. "Push twice, kick once."

The rain came harder, drumming on the canvas roof. Sam pushed twice, kicked once, and the door of the room she had waited eleven years to see swung open in front of her.

#212: Rooms you are never allowed into are never boring.



CHAPTER TWO

The Trunk



A single bulb hung from the ceiling on a string. When Sam switched it on, it swung gently, and all the shadows in the room leaned one way, then the other.

The storeroom was hardly bigger than a bathroom, and it was stacked to the ceiling. A tower of bamboo steamers. A drum of five-spice powder as tall as her knee. Jars with labels in Po-po's thin, scratchy handwriting. On the far wall, at knee height, ran a faint brown line — an old flood mark, from some year when the sea had come up the lane and into the room.

The rice sacks sat by the door, six of them, each one nearly as heavy as Sam. One at a time, she dragged them across the floor and heaved them, corner by corner, up

onto the low shelf. Above her head, the typhoon rattled the canvas, and the family radio mumbled about storm signals and shelters.

It was when she dragged the last sack away that she saw it.

At the back of the room, under a sheet of oilcloth, stood a trunk.

Not a suitcase — a real trunk, the old kind, from the days when people crossed the sea in ships. Its leather was the colour of strong tea and covered in scratches. Its brass corners had turned green with age. And stamped on the lid, in small worn letters, were three initials:

J.H.W.

Sam knew those initials. Everybody in the family knew them, because her dad would not let them forget.

On the shelf in his room stood six fat paperbacks with old-fashioned covers, about a detective in London called Sherlock Holmes, who solved things nobody else could. Every cover had a drawing of him on it, thin and sharp with a hooked nose. The doctor who wrote the stories down had been called John H. Watson.

Same name, her dad liked to say, tapping the table. Same family. That doctor was my great-great-grandfather. We are those Watsons.

Nobody in the family believed him. The trunk had come to Wing Kee with him when he married in, and he had not seen it since. Sam had never once got past the second page of any of the six books. And Po-po had put the trunk in the one room nobody was allowed into, and

there it had stayed.

The latches clicked up under her thumbs. The lid rose with a sigh of old paper.

Inside, she found four things.

The first was a small cloth book: *Cantonese and English Phrases, 1946*. It fell open at "Kindly direct me to the steamship office," which Sam thought was a sentence nobody had ever needed to say in a hurry.

The second was a bundle of notebooks tied with string, in fast, slanting handwriting. But water had got to them, years and years ago. The ink had run and drowned. Only scraps of sentences survived: *...refused to explain the boots... ...three o'clock, and no bell rang... ...I have seen many strange things, but never...* After that, nothing but clouded blue pages.

The third was a tray lined with green felt. Pressed into the felt was the shape of something that had lain there for years — and was gone. Sam looked at the empty shape for a moment. Then she decided not to think about it.

The fourth thing lay at the very bottom, wrapped in flannel, and it was heavy.

She unwrapped a pocket watch.

It was silver, worn soft and grey, on a thin little chain, and it was big — so big that her fingers wouldn't close around it. There was a hinge at its shoulder, and on top, where the little knob for winding it up should be, sat a tiny ring on a stem, exactly like a little magnifying glass.

Sam pressed it. The lid sprang open.

The face inside was pale and completely blank. No hands. No numbers. Only a ring of small marks around the edge, where the numbers should have been — and in the very centre, cut into the metal as fine as a hair, an eight-pointed star.

Sam went very still.

She knew that star. She lifted her notebook and held it beside the watch. There it was on her own cover, in her own ink: the same eight points — even the long top point that she always drew too long. Her star. On a watch that had been locked in a trunk since before her father was born.

Inside the open lid, she half-noticed something else: a circle of twelve tiny empty hollows, like egg cups for very small eggs, waiting to be filled.

She snapped the lid shut. And that was when she finally noticed the thing she should have noticed first.

The watch had been shut in that trunk for eighty years.

But it was warm. As warm as a held hand.



CHAPTER THREE

Tick

Upstairs, the radio stopped mumbling and began announcing. The typhoon had arrived. Rain swept over the canvas in great sheets, the bulb swung wider on its string, and the storeroom door rattled in its frame.

Sam knew she should go upstairs. She wrote one line first:

#213: "Just one more minute" is how every adventure starts.

She set the watch down on the floor and crouched in front of it, hands on her knees, watching.

The lid opened by itself.

There was no click and no spring. It simply swung slowly open, the way a cat opens one eye when it has been pretending, all along, to be asleep.

And on the blank face, words began to appear. They did not light up, and they were not printed. They *surfaced*, the way ink spreads through water — pale grey, then dark, then sharp and clear — until the face held three lines, as if they had been there all the time:

**221B BAKER STREET LONDON 12
NOVEMBER 1895**

Sam had seen that address before. It was printed on every one of her dad's six paperbacks, and he said it out loud whenever anybody asked where the family came

from, as a joke that only he thought was funny.

To Sam, Baker Street had never been a real place. It was a place in a book.

And underneath it, the watch had written a date a hundred and thirty-one years ago.

Then the watch began to tick.

Except it was not only the watch. The sound came from everywhere at once — from the walls, from the shelf, from under Sam's own feet. The whole room ticked, slow and steady and patient, like one enormous heartbeat.

The bulb flickered, and steadied, and burned on.

And the storeroom door, the door that got stuck in wet weather, the door that needed two pushes and a kick, swung open by itself.

Sam did not move.

Beyond the door there should have been the back of the stall: the wok, the rain, her father's voice, the whole shouting city. Instead there was a hallway. It was long and narrow, lit by a single lamp with a small yellow flame, and at the far end of it a staircase went up into the dark.

Somewhere at the top of the stairs, a violin was playing. It was a thin, quick, clever tune — and then it stopped, in the middle of a note, the way music stops when the player has heard something.

Behind Sam, Hong Kong howled. In front of her, the lamp burned steadily in a hallway that could not possibly exist, and at the top of the stairs, someone was listening.

The watch ticked in her hand like a small silver heart.

Sam stepped through the door. Her left slipper came off on the threshold, and she did not go back for it.



THE CASE CONTINUES

Chapters 4–26

Sam and Holmes have until the last tram.

The full book: 26 chapters, 16 black-and-white illustrations, a map of where the watch has been, and a “What Was Real” section separating Hong Kong history from invention.

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